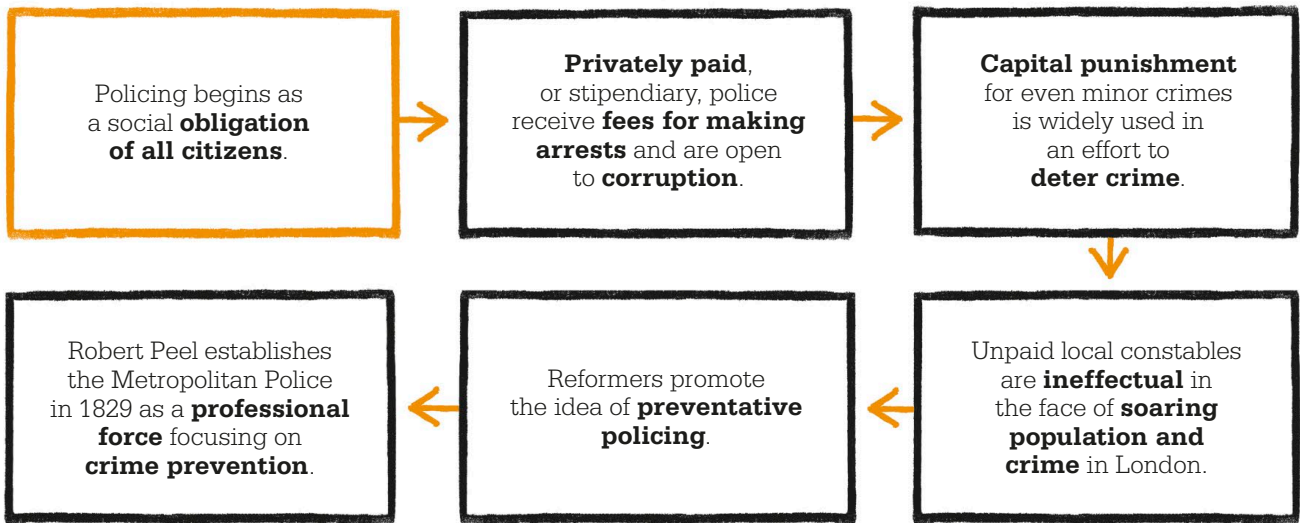




force was groundbreaking in that they took part in regular patrols—this visible deterrent proved successful, as crime on the river dropped notably.

The government resisted growing calls for a similar model to be rolled out across Britain's cities, as the cost would likely require a rise in taxes—never a popular move. Also, the dominant political ideology of the time argued for light state intervention, which seemed at

odds with an organized police force run by the state. It was likewise feared that a standing police force would be open to corruption or misuse for political ends.

The weaknesses in allowing the army to handle law and order were laid bare in the excessive use of force that resulted in the Peterloo Massacre of 1819 in Manchester. Huge but peaceful crowds of protestors calling for parliamentary reform were charged by armed

soldiers, resulting in 18 deaths and many injuries. The public were outraged and Parliament, fearing more violence, knew it had to act.

Creating a new police force

Politician Robert Peel led the call for police reform in London, which by the 1820s had a booming population and a crime rate to match. While chief secretary in Ireland, Peel had been inspired by the success of Dublin's police force. As home secretary, he focused on pushing through legislation to create a similar police force for London, arguing that lack of law and order in the capital was creating instability. By 1829, he had gained enough support for the Metropolitan Police Act to be passed.

The Metropolitan Police Act created a full-time professional police force for the London area that answered to the home secretary. Constables wore uniforms to make them easily identifiable, in blue

Use of heavy-handed armed forces

led to the 1819 Peterloo Massacre in Manchester, where peaceful demonstrators were calling for parliamentary reform.

